

'Down-to-Earth Texan' Describes Hugh Wilkin

"You get out of life, what you put in it," says Hugh Wilkin, Houston lumberman and developer, who is now "growing" homes in the beautiful Braes Terrace Addition.

For the past 51 years "Uncle" Hugh has been investing heavily in his fellowman and is collecting dividends in the form of thousands of friends and no enemies.

Most people talk about hobbies like golf, fishing, hunting and a myriad other interests . . . but these pale in significance in the face of Hugh's hobby—to make other people happy.

Native of Brenham

Mr. Wilkin is a gum-cracking, down-to-earth Texan, who came to Houston 51 years ago from his native Brenham in Washington County and started in the building trade as a carpenter's apprentice.

Since that inconspicuous start, he has tasted the bitter and sweet . . . being on top of the financial world three times and hitting the bottom twice. That puts him on top now.

He was "pretty well fixed" before World War I and again immediately after the war, but the crash that broke Wall Street's back in 1929, also broke Hugh's. He vividly recalls the lean years of "Hoover's Hog," when the armadillo was Hugh's main meat dish.

In honor of the armadillo, Hugh has built his Armadillo Club, which he donates to organizations desiring a place to meet, eat or dance. Churches are his most frequent customers.

Meteoric Rise

Mr. Wilkin's fortunes, after the crash of 1929, began to pick up in 1936, and his rise since that time has been meteoric.

He likes to see homes spring up from barren ground and while he at one time was a residential builder, he has now swung over to the developing end of the building business.

"Hugh Wilkin, Developer," is a title worn proudly by this 63-year-old, silver-thatched Texan. Some of his "projects" include the Brady, Rosedale, Rosemont, Lewisdale, Plainview, Alton Place, Temple Terrace and Braes Oaks additions.

His latest developmental plunge is the Braes Terrace Addition, south of Brays Bayou, on an extension of Buffalo Speedway.

Buys Acreage

In September of 1950, Mr. Wilkin purchased 53 acres of land for \$193,000 and started the wheels rolling for the Braes Terrace Addition. He called in 21 top Houston builders to build homes ranging in price from \$18,000 to \$70,000.

The development needed a bridge across Brays Bayou to insure its success and so Mr. Wilkin decided to build a 27-foot wide bridge, connecting 44-foot wide Buffalo Speedway with the addition.

City fathers urged him to widen his bridge to 44 feet to prevent a bottleneck that would tie up traffic on what they consider will be one of the city's main arterials.

The \$75,000 Hugh Wilkin Bridge was built 44 feet wide with some concessions given Mr. Wilkin in the paving of Braes Terrace. The bridge is now property of the city.

Daily Visits

Every day, Hugh visits the Braes Terrace Addition and delights in the beautiful homes that are beginning to dot the 193 lots in the area.

At the moment, Mr. Wilkin is having surveys made on an additional 27 acres, purchased at \$127,000 in the same area as Braes Terrace, and groundwork is to be started on a new addition. This he is calling Braes Terrace, Section Two.

Besides his interests as a developer, Mr. Wilkin also owns a lumber yard at which he makes his headquarters. The yard, located at 2302 Danville, in his own words, is "the biggest lumber yard on Danville."

That's another bit of Texan cropping out in this son of Texas . . . because the Hugh Wilkin Lumber Company is the only lumber company on Danville. The popular Armadillo Club is adjacent to the lumber company.

Gives Barbecues

When he has leisure time off from his business interests, Mr. Wilkin likes to give barbecues for his friends . . . and "Barbecue" Wilkin, as his friends call him, swings a mighty good barbecue bat at the pit.

He likes sports, and sponsors a bowling team and a baseball nine, and is always around to give "his boys" encouragement. He used to do a lot of riding and at one time owned three cattle ranches. But he got rid of the ranches, his horses, boots and saddles and even gave his spurs away . . . he's a Texan, who gave up horses for the four-wheeled iron steed.

Some 38 years ago, Hugh married pretty Miss Elsie Hickman of Bryan, and while the couple have no children, they both love them. Hugh has three or four children named after him, and thousands of his friends' children call him "Uncle."

Hugh Wilkin has come a long way since he first opened office in the old Kiam Building at Main and Preston. He's a wealthy man, but he values a man's friendship more than any material assets.



HUGH WILKIN
Houston Developer

continued on next page



THE HUGH WILKIN BRIDGE, built by Hugh Wilkin, Houston lumberman and developer of residential additions, spans Brays Bayou at the southern end of Buffalo Speedway and gives access to the new \$3,000,000 Braes Terrace Addition project. The bridge, built at a cost of about \$75,000 has been given to the city by Mr. Wilkin. Informal opening

ceremonies will be held today when the bridge will be officially opened to traffic. Eventually Buffalo Speedway will tie in with South Main and will be one of the city's main arteries. Speedway runs across the 44-foot bridge and will pierce the heart of Braes Terrace, running 44-feet wide all the way.